

IN THE BEGINNING WAS THE TAIL

The 2025 Women's World Cup redrew cricket's hierarchies, as those who batted last **dictated** how far their teams went.

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For much of the Women's ODI World Cup 2025, the lower order was the story: rescuing innings, turning games, and redefining what it meant to bat at No. 8 to 11.

But in the final, the top and middle-order batters held firm, leaving little for the tail to do as the contest was largely decided before they were needed.

Yet the deeper story of the tournament lay in a rare symmetry: India and South Africa, the two sides with the most productive lower-order hitters, reached the final and closed their campaigns with identical tallies — 279 runs from their last four batters.

It was as if the late-order architects themselves had mapped out the path to the title clash, proving that in modern women's

RICHA GHOSH WAS THE TOURNAMENT'S FASTEST SCORER AS WELL AS ITS HIGHEST SIX-HITTER, HAVING STRUCK 12 MAXIMUMS IN EIGHT GAMES

